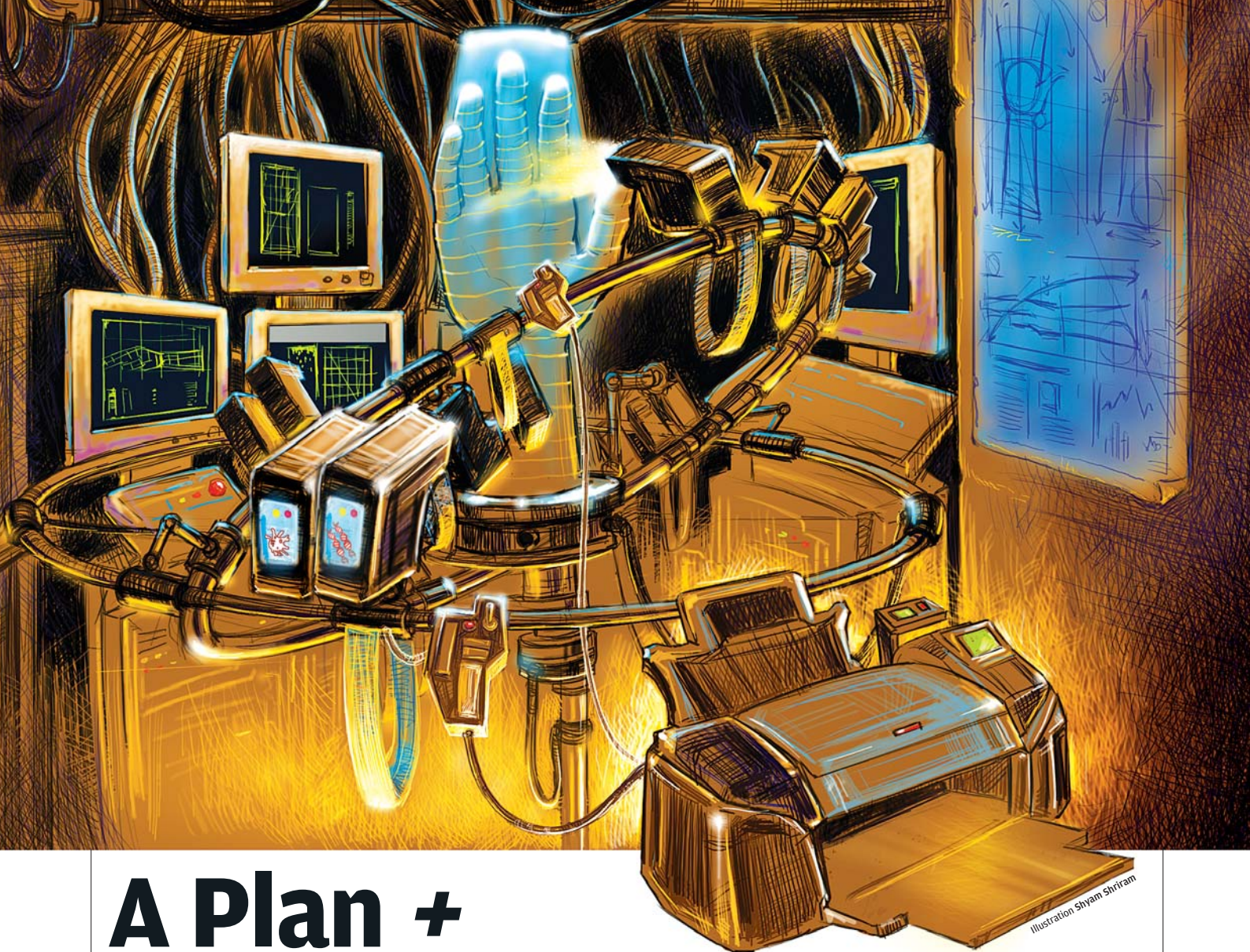




A Plan + A Printer = A Product!

The exquisite technology behind the inkjet is so versatile, the uses are virtually limitless. "Take a plan and print it out" could soon work for almost anything—from MP3 players to houses!

Ram Mohan Rao

At the Shared Tissue Engineering Laboratory at the Medical University of South Carolina, scientists use machines to 'print out' skin. The printed skin could eventually replace skin grafting, which is used for burn victims as well as for cosmetic purposes. The machines are shooting out the proteins that will constitute the skin, and the tissue is being captured on specialised gel.

There's probably nothing overly interesting about that, but what's amazing here is that the machines are old HP and Canon inkjet printers!

Whoever said the unassuming inkjet could only be used for printing out documents, reports and such? Certainly not the inventors of the technology! They were experimenting with a variety of uses for it, and it just so happened that printing on paper got most quickly commercialised. Now, researchers are going back to their drawing boards and finding seemingly exotic, yet eminently practical, uses for the technology behind the print nozzle.

You see, the print nozzle is an exquisite piece of technology: it has many, many holes, and squeezes out extremely tiny droplets of whatever is in the cartridge. That's where its potential lies. Instead of just ink, you could think of anything